

Chapter 6 — Civilising the "Native", Educating the Nation

The one-line point: The British disagreed among themselves about **whether to revive Indian learning or replace it**. Macaulay won, English won — and then **Gandhi and Tagore rejected the whole enterprise** and built alternatives. This chapter is a debate, not a narrative.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Modern India
Sub-discipline	Colonial education policy & Indian responses
Period	1781 – 1940s
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>History of India</i> → Orientalists, Macaulay's Minute, English Education Act, Wood's Despatch
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ Modern Indian history ; also Indian culture (Santiniketan); social reform
Also feeds	Polity/Governance ★ ★ (education policy, NEP debates on mother tongue), Ethics (GS4) ★ ★ (Gandhi's philosophy of education — a recurring theme), Essay ★ ★ (education, language, self-respect)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ — Macaulay and Wood's Despatch are near-certain Prelims content
Overlaps with	Ch.1 (James Mill again), Ch.5 (English education as a 1857 grievance), Ch.8 (the educated middle class leads the movement)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain Orientalism** — who, when, what they believed, and what they founded. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Name the Calcutta Madrasa (1781) and the Hindu College, Benaras (1791).** ★ ★
- ☐ **State the Anglicist case — James Mill and Macaulay — and quote Macaulay.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the English Education Act, 1835.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain Wood's Despatch (1854) and its three arguments.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **List the measures that followed, including the three universities of 1857.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the missionaries' position and Serampore.** ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the pathshala from William Adam's report, with its numbers.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain how the new rules destroyed the pathshala's flexibility — and who lost.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **State Gandhi's critique** of English education and his positive philosophy. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe Tagore's Santiniketan and compare Tagore with Gandhi.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **State Aurobindo Ghose's view of national education.** ★

Start Here: The "Cultural Mission"

"The British in India wanted **not only territorial conquest and control over revenues**. They also felt that they had a **CULTURAL MISSION**: they had to '**CIVILISE THE NATIVES**', **change their customs and values**."

But — and this is the whole chapter —

★ ★ "What changes were to be introduced? How were Indians to be educated, 'civilised', and made into what the British believed were 'good subjects'? **The British could find NO SIMPLE ANSWERS to these questions. They continued to be DEBATED FOR MANY DECADES.**"

THE THREE POSITIONS, and then the Indian answer

- [1] ORIENTALISTS → revive and teach INDIAN learning
(Jones, Colebrooke, Halhed; supported by Warren Hastings)
↓
- [2] ANGLICISTS → replace it with WESTERN learning in ENGLISH
(James Mill, Macaulay) -- *** THEY WON, 1835 ***
↓
- [3] MISSIONARIES → education must improve MORAL character,
possible only through CHRISTIAN education
↓
- [4] THE INDIAN RESPONSE (early 20th century)
GANDHI → English education ENSLAVED us; teach handicrafts
in Indian languages
TAGORE → the school is a PRISON; learn in nature, creatively,
combining East and West

 **Read the chapter as an argument with four parties, not a chronology.** That structure is what a Mains answer needs.

1 ★ ★ ★ The Orientalists

William Jones

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Arrived	Calcutta, 1783, as a junior judge at the Supreme Court the Company had set up
★ His skills	An expert in law and a LINGUIST — had studied Greek and Latin at Oxford , knew French and English , picked up Arabic from a friend, and had learnt Persian
In Calcutta	"He began spending many hours a day with PANDITS who taught him the subtleties of Sanskrit language, grammar and poetry "
What he studied	Ancient Indian texts on law, philosophy, religion, politics, morality, arithmetic, medicine and the other sciences

★ ★ His colleagues and their institutions:

Name	Detail
★ Henry Thomas Colebrooke	"A scholar of Sanskrit and ancient sacred writings of Hinduism"
★ Nathaniel Halhed	(You met him in Ch.2 — he translated the 1775 digest of Hindu laws)
★ ★ What they founded	The ★ ASIATIC SOCIETY OF BENGAL , and a journal called ★ ASIATICK RESEARCHES

★★★ What the Orientalists believed

"They shared a DEEP RESPECT FOR ANCIENT CULTURES, both of India and the West."

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*** "Indian civilisation, they felt, had ATTAINED ITS GLORY IN THE ANCIENT PAST, BUT HAD SUBSEQUENTLY DECLINED." ***

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"In order to UNDERSTAND India, it was necessary to DISCOVER THE SACRED AND LEGAL TEXTS produced in the ancient period. For ONLY THOSE TEXTS could reveal the real ideas and laws of the Hindus and Muslims, and only a NEW STUDY OF THESE TEXTS could form the BASIS OF FUTURE DEVELOPMENT in India."

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The project would (a) "help the BRITISH LEARN from Indian culture" and (b) "help INDIANS REDISCOVER THEIR OWN HERITAGE, and understand the lost glories of their past."

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*** "In this process, the British would become the GUARDIANS OF INDIAN CULTURE AS WELL AS ITS MASTERS." ***

★★★ That final line is NCERT's sharpest observation in the chapter, and it should go into any answer on Orientalism.

Orientalism looks like respect, and in part it was. But it **also produced a claim to authority**: if Indians had forgotten their own glory, and the British had recovered it, then **the British were the legitimate custodians of Indian tradition. Admiration and domination were not in conflict here — they reinforced each other.**

⚠️ **And note the built-in condescension**: the greatness is always **in the past**, and the present is always **decline**. That framing licences intervention just as effectively as Macaulay's contempt does — it simply flatters while doing it.

★★ The institutions they built

Institution	Year	Purpose
★★ Calcutta MADRASA	1781	To promote the study of Arabic, Persian and Islamic law
★★ HINDU COLLEGE, BENARAS	1791	To encourage the study of ancient Sanskrit texts that would be useful for the administration of the country

Their argument for this: Hindus and Muslims **"ought to be taught what they were already familiar with, and what they valued and treasured**, not subjects that were alien to them. **Only then could the British hope to win a place in the hearts of the 'natives'; only then could the alien rulers expect to be RESPECTED BY THEIR SUBJECTS.**"*

★ **Warren Hastings** was *"an enthusiastic supporter of the Orientalists"*, took the initiative to set up the Calcutta Madrasa, and **"believed that the ancient customs of the country and Oriental learning ought to be the BASIS OF BRITISH RULE in India."**

🎯 **Note the Westmacott monument NCERT describes** — Hastings standing **between a pandit and a seated munshi**. The Orientalists **needed** Indian scholars to teach them vernaculars, explain local custom and law, and help translate texts. **The image records a dependence that the "guardians of Indian culture" line conceals.**

Definitions to know: ★ **Orientalists** = those with a **scholarly knowledge of the language and culture of Asia**. ★ **Munshi** = a person who can **read, write and teach Persian**. ★ **Madrassa** = an Arabic word for a **place of learning**; any type of school or college.

2 ★ ★ ★ "Grave Errors of the East" — the Anglicist Attack

James Mill

From the **early nineteenth century**, many officials began to criticise the Orientalist vision. *"They said that **knowledge of the East was FULL OF ERRORS and UNSCIENTIFIC THOUGHT**; Eastern literature was **NON-SERIOUS and LIGHT-HEARTED**."*

★ ★ Mill's argument:

*"The British effort, he declared, **should NOT be to teach what the natives wanted, or what they respected, in order to please them and 'win a place in their heart'**. ★ **The aim of education ought to be to teach WHAT WAS USEFUL AND PRACTICAL**. So Indians should be made familiar with the **SCIENTIFIC AND TECHNICAL ADVANCES that the West had made**, rather than with the **poetry and sacred literature of the Orient**."*

🔗 **The same James Mill from Chapter 1** — author of *A History of British India* (1817) and of the Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation. **His view of education follows directly from his view of history**: if the Indian past was darkness, there is nothing in it worth teaching.

★ ★ ★ Thomas Babington Macaulay

Fact	Detail
When	<i>"By the 1830s the attack on the Orientalists became sharper"</i>
Who	<i>"One of the most outspoken and influential of such critics"</i>
★ ★ His view	<i>"He saw India as an UNCIVILISED COUNTRY THAT NEEDED TO BE CIVILISED. NO BRANCH of Eastern knowledge could be compared to what England had produced."</i>

★ ★ ★ The famous line — know it verbatim:

*"Who could deny, declared Macaulay, that '**A SINGLE SHELF OF A GOOD EUROPEAN LIBRARY WAS WORTH THE WHOLE NATIVE LITERATURE OF INDIA AND ARABIA**'. "*

★ And from his Minute of 2 February 1835:

*"All parties seem to be agreed on one point, that **the dialects commonly spoken among the natives of India contain neither literary nor scientific information**, and are, moreover, **so poor and rude that, until they are enriched from some other quarter, it will not be easy to translate any valuable work into them**."*

His positive case for English: knowledge of English *"would allow Indians to **read some of the finest literature the world had produced**; it would make them **aware of the developments in Western science and philosophy**."* ★ **"Teaching of English could thus be a way of CIVILISING PEOPLE, CHANGING THEIR TASTES, VALUES AND CULTURE."**

He urged the government to **stop wasting public money promoting Oriental learning, "for it was of no practical use."**

★ ★ ★ The English Education Act, 1835

"Following Macaulay's MINUTE, the *** ENGLISH EDUCATION ACT OF 1835 *** was introduced."

THE DECISION:

- [1] to make *** ENGLISH THE MEDIUM OF INSTRUCTION FOR HIGHER EDUCATION ***
- [2] to *** STOP THE PROMOTION OF ORIENTAL INSTITUTIONS *** like the CALCUTTA MADRASA and BENARAS SANSKRIT COLLEGE

These institutions were dismissed as
*** "TEMPLES OF DARKNESS THAT WERE FALLING OF THEMSELVES INTO DECAY" ***

"ENGLISH TEXTBOOKS now began to be produced for schools."

★ ★ ★ **1835 is one of the most consequential dates in modern Indian history.** It created the English-educated class that would, within fifty years, **found the Indian National Congress** — the exact opposite of what Macaulay intended. **Note that irony in a Mains answer:** the instrument designed to produce loyal subjects produced the leadership of the freedom movement.

3 ★ ★ ★ Wood's Despatch, 1854 — "Education for Commerce"

Fact	Detail
★ ★ What	In 1854 the Court of Directors of the East India Company in London sent an educational despatch to the Governor-General
★ ★ Who	Issued by CHARLES WOOD , President of the Board of Control of the Company
★ Its thrust	It emphasised " <i>once again the PRACTICAL BENEFITS of a system of EUROPEAN LEARNING, as opposed to Oriental knowledge</i> "

★ ★ ★ Its three arguments

- [1] *** ECONOMIC ***
"European learning would enable Indians to **RECOGNISE THE ADVANTAGES** that flow from the **EXPANSION OF TRADE AND COMMERCE**, and make them see the importance of **DEVELOPING THE RESOURCES** of the country."

AND -- the frank part:
"Introducing them to European **WAYS OF LIFE** would **CHANGE THEIR TASTES AND DESIRES**, and *** **CREATE A DEMAND FOR BRITISH GOODS** ***, for Indians would begin to **APPRECIATE AND BUY** things that were **PRODUCED IN EUROPE**."

- [2] *** MORAL ***
"European learning would **IMPROVE THE MORAL CHARACTER** of Indians. It would make them **TRUTHFUL AND HONEST**, and thus *** **SUPPLY THE COMPANY WITH CIVIL SERVANTS WHO COULD BE TRUSTED AND DEPENDED UPON**. ***"

- [3] *** AGAINST THE EAST ***
"The literature of the East was not only **FULL OF GRAVE ERRORS**, it could also **NOT INSTIL** in people a **SENSE OF DUTY** and a **COMMITMENT TO WORK**, nor could it develop the **SKILLS REQUIRED FOR ADMINISTRATION**."

★ And the Despatch's own words:

*"We must **emphatically declare** that the education which we desire to see extended in India is that which has for its object **the diffusion of the improved arts, services, philosophy, and literature of Europe — in short, EUROPEAN KNOWLEDGE.**"*

★★★ Argument [1] is remarkable for its candour and is the single most quotable thing in this chapter.

Education is openly justified as a means of creating consumer demand for British manufactures. Not as a public good, not even primarily as civilisation — as **market development**.

🎯 Deploy it whenever you write about the economics of colonialism. It shows that the "civilising mission" and the commercial interest were not separate justifications running in parallel — **in this document they are the same argument**. Wood's Despatch is described by NCERT as marking "*the FINAL TRIUMPH of those who opposed Oriental learning.*"

⚠️ And note argument [2]'s real content: moral improvement is desirable because it yields **trustworthy civil servants**. Even the ethical case is instrumental.

★★ The measures that followed

Measure	Detail
★ Education departments	Set up "to extend CONTROL over all matters regarding education "
★★ Universities	"Steps were taken to establish a system of university education" — ★★★ in 1857, while the sepoys rose in revolt in Meerut and Delhi, universities were being established in CALCUTTA, MADRAS and BOMBAY
Schools	"Attempts were also made to bring about changes within the system of school education"

★★★ NCERT's juxtaposition of 1857 is deliberate and worth using. In the very year of the revolt, the three presidency universities were founded. Coercion and cultivation were two arms of the same state, operating simultaneously. That single sentence makes an excellent opening or closing line for an essay on colonial rule.

4 ★★ The Missionaries — a Third Position

Their view	Detail
★ Their critique	"The argument for practical education was strongly criticised by the Christian missionaries"
★★ Their claim	"Education should attempt to improve the MORAL CHARACTER of the people , and morality could be improved ONLY through CHRISTIAN EDUCATION "

★★ Why Serampore — a neat historical detail:

"Until *** 1813 *** the East India Company was OPPOSED to missionary activities in India."

WHY? "It feared that missionary activities would PROVOKE REACTION amongst the local population and make them SUSPICIOUS OF BRITISH PRESENCE in India."

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"UNABLE TO ESTABLISH AN INSTITUTION WITHIN BRITISH-CONTROLLED TERRITORIES, the missionaries set up a mission at *** SERAMPORE *** -- in an area under the control of the *** DANISH East India Company. ***"

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A PRINTING PRESS was set up in *** 1800 ***

A COLLEGE was established in *** 1818 ***

★ And the post-1857 retreat:

*"Over the nineteenth century, missionary schools were set up all over India. **After 1857, however, the British government in India was RELUCTANT TO DIRECTLY SUPPORT MISSIONARY EDUCATION.** There was a feeling that **any strong attack on local customs, practices, beliefs and religious ideas might ENRAGE 'NATIVE' OPINION.**"*

🔗 Straight from Chapter 5's post-revolt change [5] — "the British decided to respect the customary religious and social practices." 1857 disciplined the state's appetite for cultural interference. William Carey was the Scottish missionary who helped establish the Serampore Mission.

5 ★★ ★ What Happened to the Local Schools — William Adam's Report

Fact	Detail
★★ Who and when	WILLIAM ADAM , a Scottish missionary , toured the districts of Bengal and Bihar in the 1830s , asked by the Company to report on the progress of education in vernacular schools
★★★ What he found	★ Over 1 LAKH PATHSHALAS in Bengal and Bihar — small institutions with no more than 20 students each , but ★ a total of OVER 20 LAKH children being taught
★ Who ran them	*"Set up by wealthy people, or the LOCAL COMMUNITY . At times they were started by a teacher (GURU) "*

★★★ What the pathshala did *not* have

"Few things that you associate with schools today were present:

NO fixed fee	NO printed books
NO separate building	NO benches or chairs
NO blackboards	NO separate classes
NO roll-call registers	NO annual examinations
NO regular time-table"	

And what it did have:

Feature	Detail
Venue	"In some places, classes were held under a banyan tree , in others in the corner of a village shop or temple , or at the guru's home "
★ ★ Fees	" Fee depended on the INCOME OF PARENTS: the rich had to pay more than the poor "
Method	"Teaching was ORAL , and the guru decided what to teach, in accordance with the NEEDS OF THE STUDENTS "
★ Grouping	"Students were not separated into different classes: all of them sat together in one place . The guru interacted separately with groups of children with different levels of learning "
★ ★ ★ The crucial flexibility	" Classes were NOT HELD DURING HARVEST TIME , when rural children often worked in the fields. The pathshala started once again when the crops had been cut and stored. ★ THIS MEANT THAT EVEN CHILDREN OF PEASANT FAMILIES COULD STUDY. "*

★ ★ ★ Adam's finding is genuinely striking and worth internalising: over a lakh schools and twenty lakh students, before any colonial education policy existed.

And every feature that looks like an absence was actually an adaptation. Sliding-scale fees meant the poor could attend. No fixed timetable meant the harvest could be worked. Mixed-age groups meant one guru could serve a village. **The system had no infrastructure precisely because it needed none.**

 **It was demand-shaped rather than standardised** — the curriculum, the calendar and the price all adjusted to the local user. What it lacked in uniformity it gained in **access**.

⚠ ★ ★ ★ New routines, new rules — and who lost

"Up to the mid-nineteenth century, the Company was concerned primarily with HIGHER education. So it ALLOWED THE LOCAL PATHSHALAS TO FUNCTION WITHOUT MUCH INTERFERENCE."

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*** "AFTER 1854, the Company decided to IMPROVE the system of VERNACULAR education." ***
It felt this could be done by "INTRODUCING ORDER within the system, IMPOSING ROUTINES, ESTABLISHING RULES, ensuring REGULAR INSPECTIONS."

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THE MEASURES:

- appointed *** GOVERNMENT PANDITS ***, each in charge of *** FOUR TO FIVE SCHOOLS ***, to visit the pathshalas and improve the standard of teaching
- each guru had to submit *** PERIODIC REPORTS *** and take classes according to a *** REGULAR TIMETABLE ***
- teaching now based on *** TEXTBOOKS ***
- learning tested by *** ANNUAL EXAMINATION ***
- students to pay a *** REGULAR FEE ***, attend *** REGULAR CLASSES ***, sit on *** FIXED SEATS ***, and obey new rules of *** DISCIPLINE ***

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"Pathshalas which ACCEPTED the new rules were supported through *** GOVERNMENT GRANTS. *** Those UNWILLING to work within the new system received NO government support."

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"Over time, gurus who wanted to RETAIN THEIR INDEPENDENCE found it DIFFICULT TO COMPETE with the government aided and regulated pathshalas."

★ ★ ★ And the consequence NCERT drives home:

*"The new rules and routines had **another consequence**. In the earlier system, **children from POOR PEASANT FAMILIES had been able to go to pathshalas, since the timetable was FLEXIBLE**. The discipline of the new system **demand**ed **REGULAR ATTENDANCE, EVEN DURING HARVEST TIME** when children of poor families had to work in the fields. ★★ **INABILITY TO ATTEND SCHOOL CAME TO BE SEEN AS INDISCIPLINE, AS EVIDENCE OF THE LACK OF DESIRE TO LEARN.**"*

★★★ This is the finest passage in the chapter and outstanding Mains and Essay material.

A **poverty constraint was reclassified as a character defect**. The child who could not attend during harvest was not recorded as *poor*; he was recorded as *undisciplined* and *unwilling to learn*. **The system did not merely exclude him — it blamed him for his own exclusion.**

📖 **Standardisation improved measurability and destroyed accessibility.** The reformed pathshala was easier to inspect, grade and fund — and unusable by the people the old one had served. **And because the metric only recorded attendance, the failure looked like the student's.**

🎯 Use this in answers on educational inequality, dropout rates, or any policy where uniform standards meet unequal circumstances. NCERT itself nudges you there with an activity noting that about 50 per cent of children drop out of primary school by 13 or 14.

6 ★★ ★ The Agenda for a National Education

From the early nineteenth century, many Indian thinkers began to call for a wider spread of education. **Some**, impressed by Europe, *"felt that Western education would help modernise India"* and **urged the British to open more schools, colleges and universities.** ★ **"There were other Indians, however, who REACTED AGAINST Western education."**

👤 ★★ ★ Mahatma Gandhi — "English education has enslaved us"

The critique:

Argument	Detail
★★ Inferiority	"Colonial education created a sense of INFERIORITY in the minds of Indians. It made them see Western civilisation as superior , and destroyed the pride they had in their own culture "
★ His language	" There was POISON in this education , said Mahatma Gandhi, it was SINFUL , it ENSLAVED Indians , it cast an EVIL SPELL on them"
The effect	"Charmed by the West... Indians educated in these institutions began ADMIRING BRITISH RULE "
★★ His action	"During the national movement, he urged students to LEAVE educational institutions in order to show the British that Indians were no longer willing to be enslaved "

★★ On language:

*"Mahatma Gandhi strongly felt that **INDIAN LANGUAGES ought to be the MEDIUM OF TEACHING**. Education in English **crippled Indians, DISTANCED THEM FROM THEIR OWN SOCIAL SURROUNDINGS**, and made them ★ **'STRANGERS IN THEIR OWN LANDS'**. Speaking a foreign tongue, despising local culture, **the English educated DID NOT KNOW HOW TO RELATE TO THE MASSES.**"*

🎯 **That last clause is politically shrewd, not merely cultural.** Gandhi's objection is that **English education produced a leadership that could not communicate with the people it claimed to lead.** His own insistence on vernaculars was a **mass-mobilisation strategy** as much as a philosophical position — which is why his movement reached where the earlier Congress had not (Ch.8).

★ ★ ★ **And his positive philosophy:**

Claim	Detail
Against textbook learning	Western education " <i>focused on reading and writing rather than ORAL KNOWLEDGE; it valued TEXTBOOKS rather than LIVED EXPERIENCE and PRACTICAL KNOWLEDGE</i> "
★ ★ The purpose	"Education ought to develop a person's MIND AND SOUL "
★ ★ ★ The famous claim	*" LITERACY — or simply learning to read and write — BY ITSELF DID NOT COUNT AS EDUCATION. "*
★ ★ The method	"People had to WORK WITH THEIR HANDS, LEARN A CRAFT, and KNOW HOW DIFFERENT THINGS OPERATED. This would develop their mind and their capacity to understand "

★ ★ **In his own words:**

*"By education I mean an **all-round drawing out of the best in child and man — body, mind and spirit. Literacy is not the end of education nor even the beginning.** It is only one of the means... **Literacy in itself is not education.** I would therefore **begin the child's education by teaching it a USEFUL HANDICRAFT** and enabling it to **produce from the moment it begins its training... only every handicraft has to be taught NOT MERELY MECHANICALLY** as is done today **but SCIENTIFICALLY, i.e. the child should know the WHY AND THE WHEREFORE of every process.**"*

★ ★ ★ **Prime GS4 Ethics material, and note the crucial qualifier most people miss: "not merely mechanically but SCIENTIFICALLY — the child should know the why and the wherefore."**

Gandhi is not proposing vocational training as an alternative to thinking. He is proposing that **understanding is best reached through making**, provided the making is accompanied by the reasoning behind it. That is a serious pedagogical claim, and it anticipates modern arguments for experiential learning.

🔗 **This became the *Nai Talim* / Basic Education scheme (Wardha, 1937) — worth knowing beyond the text.**

🌳 ★★ ★★ ★★ Rabindranath Tagore — Santiniketan

Fact	Detail
★★ ★★ Founded	1901
★★ ★★ Why	"As a child, Tagore HATED going to school . He found it SUFFOCATING AND OPPRESSIVE . ★ The school appeared like a PRISON , for he could never do what he felt like doing"
★★ ★★ His ideal	"He wanted to set up a school where the child was HAPPY , where she could be FREE AND CREATIVE , where she was able to EXPLORE HER OWN THOUGHTS AND DESIRES "
★ ★ On childhood	"Childhood ought to be a time of SELF-LEARNING , outside the rigid and restricting discipline of the schooling system set up by the British"
★ ★ On teachers	"Teachers had to be IMAGINATIVE, UNDERSTAND THE CHILD , and help the child DEVELOP HER CURIOSITY "
★★ ★★ His charge	"The existing schools KILLED THE NATURAL DESIRE OF THE CHILD TO BE CREATIVE, her SENSE OF WONDER "
★★ ★★ The setting	"Creative learning could be encouraged only within a NATURAL ENVIRONMENT . So he chose to set up his school 100 KILOMETRES away from Calcutta, in a RURAL setting "
★ ★ The name	★ SANTINIKETAN = "an ABODE OF PEACE " — "where, living in harmony with nature, children could cultivate their natural creativity"

★★ ★★ ★★ Gandhi vs Tagore — the comparison NCERT sets up

	GANDHI	TAGORE
Shared ground	Both rejected the colonial schooling system ; both wanted education to develop the whole person ; both valued Indian languages and settings	← same
★★ ★★ On Western civilisation	★ "Highly critical of Western civilisation and its WORSHIP OF MACHINES AND TECHNOLOGY "	★ "Wanted to COMBINE elements of MODERN WESTERN CIVILISATION with what he saw as THE BEST WITHIN INDIAN TRADITION "
★★ ★★ Curriculum	Handicraft at the centre; learn by working with the hands	★ "Emphasised the need to teach SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY at Santiniketan, ALONG WITH ART, MUSIC AND DANCE "
On discipline	Self-discipline through productive work	★ Freedom from rigid discipline; self-learning; creativity

★★ ★★ ★★ This comparison is a stock question and the distinction is precise: Gandhi rejected Western civilisation; Tagore rejected only the Western school.

Tagore taught **science and technology** at Santiniketan; Gandhi was suspicious of **machines and technology** as such. **Same critique of colonial education, different verdict on modernity.**

★ Aurobindo Ghose on national education

In a speech on **15 January 1908** in **Bombay**, **Aurobindo Ghose** stated that:

Claim

★ **The goal of national education was to AWAKEN THE SPIRIT OF NATIONALITY** among students

This required a **contemplation of the heroic deeds of our ancestors**

★ **Education should be imparted IN THE VERNACULAR**, so as to **reach the largest number of people**

Students should **remain connected to their own roots** but ★ **also take the fullest advantage of MODERN SCIENTIFIC DISCOVERIES and WESTERN EXPERIMENTS IN POPULAR GOVERNMENT**

They should also **learn some useful crafts** so as to find **moderately remunerative employment** after school

★ **Aurobindo occupies a middle position** — vernacular medium and national spirit, **but** modern science and Western political experience, **plus** crafts for employment. **Closer to Tagore than to Gandhi on modernity, closer to Gandhi on crafts.**

★★ The unresolved question

*"Some wanted **changes within the system set up by the British**, and felt that the system could be **extended so as to include wider sections of people**. Others urged that **ALTERNATIVE SYSTEMS be created** so that people were educated into a culture that was **truly national**. ★★ **WHO WAS TO DEFINE WHAT WAS TRULY NATIONAL? The debate about what this 'national education' ought to be CONTINUED TILL AFTER INDEPENDENCE.**"*

🎯 **NCERT ends on an open question, and it is still open.** Medium of instruction, mother tongue versus English, the place of craft and vocational training, what a "national" curriculum should contain — **every one of these is a live policy debate today (NEP 2020)**. That makes this chapter unusually easy to connect to current affairs in an essay or GS2 answer.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
William Jones ★★ ★★	Arrived Calcutta 1783 as a junior judge; linguist ; founded the Asiatic Society of Bengal and Asiatic Researches
Colebrooke, Halhed ★	Fellow Orientalists
Orientalist belief ★★ ★★	Indian civilisation glorious in the ancient past, since declined ; recover the sacred and legal texts ; the British as guardians AND masters
Calcutta Madrasa ★★	1781 — Arabic, Persian, Islamic law
Hindu College, Benaras ★★	1791 — ancient Sanskrit texts
Warren Hastings ★	Enthusiastic supporter of the Orientalists
James Mill ★★	Attacked the Orientalists; education must be useful and practical
Macaulay ★★ ★★	1830s ; " <i>a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia</i> "; Minute of 2 February 1835
English Education Act ★★ ★★	1835 — English the medium of higher education ; stop promoting Oriental institutions, " <i>temples of darkness</i> "
Wood's Despatch ★★ ★★	1854 ; Charles Wood, President of the Board of Control ; economic + moral arguments; " create a demand for British goods "
Universities ★★ ★★	1857 — Calcutta, Madras and Bombay (the year of the revolt)
Missionaries ★★	Company opposed them until 1813 ; Serampore under the DANISH East India Company; press 1800, college 1818 ; William Carey ; support withdrawn after 1857
William Adam ★★ ★★	Scottish missionary ; toured Bengal and Bihar in the 1830s ; found over 1 lakh pathshalas and over 20 lakh students
Pathshala features ★★ ★★	No fixed fee, printed books, building, benches, blackboard, classes, registers, exams or timetable; fee scaled to parents' income ; oral teaching ; no classes at harvest time
Post-1854 rules ★★ ★★	Government pandits over 4–5 schools each ; periodic reports, timetable, textbooks, annual exams, regular fee and attendance ; grants for compliance
The consequence ★★ ★★	Poor children excluded; inability to attend read as INDISCIPLINE
Gandhi ★★ ★★	English education enslaved ; " strangers in their own lands "; ★ " literacy in itself is not education "; begin with a handicraft , taught scientifically
Tagore ★★ ★★	Santiniketan, 1901 ; " abode of peace "; 100 km from Calcutta ; school as a prison ; taught science and technology alongside art, music and dance
Gandhi vs Tagore ★★ ★★	Gandhi critical of Western civilisation and machines ; Tagore combined West with Indian tradition
Aurobindo Ghose ★	15 January 1908, Bombay ; national education to awaken the spirit of nationality ; vernacular medium ; also modern science and Western popular government

Traps:

- "**James Mill supported the Orientalists**" → **FALSE**. He was a **severe critic** (NCERT true/false)
- "**Gandhi thought promoting literacy was the most important aim of education**" → **FALSE**. "*Literacy in itself is not education*" (NCERT true/false)

- "Tagore felt children should be subjected to strict discipline" → **FALSE**. The opposite (*NCERT true/false*)
- "Serampore was in British territory" → **FALSE**. Under the **DANISH** East India Company
- "The universities were founded in 1854" → **FALSE**. Wood's Despatch was 1854; the **universities came in 1857**
- "Tagore rejected Western science" → **FALSE**. He **taught science and technology** at Santiniketan; it was **Gandhi** who was critical of machines
- "Wood's Despatch favoured Oriental learning" → **FALSE**. It marked the **final triumph** of its opponents

Mains

- ★★ ★ *"Colonial education policy served commercial and administrative ends more than civilisational ones."* Discuss — **Wood's Despatch's "demand for British goods" is your decisive evidence**
- ★★ ★ *"Orientalism was a form of respect that produced a claim to authority."* Examine — *"guardians of Indian culture as well as its masters"*
- ★★ ★ **Ethics/Essay:** Gandhi's philosophy of education — *"literacy in itself is not education"*; learning through craft, taught **scientifically**
- ★★ ★ *"Standardisation of the vernacular schools improved order and reduced access."* Discuss — the pathshala case, and the reclassification of poverty as indiscipline
- ★★ **Compare Gandhi and Tagore** on education and on modernity
- ★★ **Contemporary link:** medium of instruction and mother-tongue teaching in **NEP 2020**, traced to this nineteenth-century debate

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Orientalists	Those with scholarly knowledge of the language and culture of Asia
Linguist	Someone who knows and studies several languages
Madrasa	An Arabic word for a place of learning; any school or college
Munshi	A person who can read, write and teach Persian
Vernacular	A local language or dialect, as distinct from the standard — used by the British to mark local speech off from English
Pathshala	A local Indian school
Guru	The teacher of a pathshala
Minute	A formal note recording an opinion — as in Macaulay's Minute of 1835
Despatch	An official communication — as in Wood's Despatch of 1854
Santiniketan	"Abode of peace" — Tagore's school, 1901

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. The British claimed a "**cultural mission**" to *"civilise the natives"* — but **could find no simple answer** to how, and **debated it for decades**.
2. ★ **ORIENTALISTS: William Jones** (Calcutta, **1783**), **Colebrooke**, **Halhed** — founded the **Asiatic Society of Bengal** and **Asiatick Researches**. They believed Indian civilisation had been **glorious in the**

ancient past and had declined, and that recovering its texts would let Indians **rediscover their heritage** — making the British ★ **"guardians of Indian culture as well as its masters."**

3. Their institutions: the ★ **Calcutta Madrasa (1781)** and the ★ **Hindu College, Benaras (1791)**. **Warren Hastings** backed them.
4. ★ **ANGLICISTS: James Mill** said education should teach **what was useful and practical**, not what pleased Indians. **Macaulay** called India uncivilised and declared ★ *"a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia."*
5. ★★ **The English Education Act, 1835** made **English the medium of higher education** and stopped support for Oriental institutions, dismissed as **"temples of darkness."**
6. ★★ **Wood's Despatch, 1854** (**Charles Wood**, President of the Board of Control): European learning would expand trade, **"create a demand for British goods"**, and supply **trustworthy civil servants**. It marked the **final triumph** of the Anglicists.
7. ★ It was followed by **education departments** and, in ★ **1857 — the year of the revolt — universities at Calcutta, Madras and Bombay**.
8. **Missionaries** insisted morality required **Christian** education. Barred by the Company until **1813**, they built at ★ **Serampore** in **Danish** territory — **press 1800, college 1818**. After **1857** the government grew **reluctant to support them**, fearing to enrage native opinion.
9. ★★ **William Adam** found in the **1830s** over ★ **1 lakh pathshalas** teaching over ★ **20 lakh children** in Bengal and Bihar — with **no fixed fees, buildings, books, classes, exams or timetable, fees scaled to income, oral teaching**, and ★ **no classes during harvest, so peasant children could attend**.
10. ★★ ★ **After 1854 the state standardised them** — government pandits, reports, timetables, textbooks, annual exams, fixed fees and seats, with **grants for compliance**. Independent gurus **could not compete**, and poor children **could no longer attend during harvest** — ★ **"inability to attend school came to be seen as indiscipline, as evidence of the lack of desire to learn."**
11. ★★ **Gandhi**: colonial education created **inferiority**, made Indians **"strangers in their own lands"**, and left the educated unable to **relate to the masses**. ★ **"Literacy in itself is not education."** Begin with a **handicraft** — taught **scientifically**, so the child knows **"the why and the wherefore."**
12. ★★ **Tagore** founded **Santiniketan in 1901, 100 km from Calcutta** — an **"abode of peace"** where children learn **freely and creatively in nature**, because schools **killed the child's sense of wonder**.
13. ★★ **The difference: Gandhi was critical of Western civilisation and its worship of machines; Tagore combined the West with the best of Indian tradition and taught science and technology alongside art, music and dance**.
14. **Aurobindo Ghose (1908)** wanted national education to **awaken the spirit of nationality**, taught **in the vernacular**, while embracing **modern science and Western popular government**.
15. ★ **"Who was to define what was truly national?"** — the question NCERT leaves open, and which **continued past independence**.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Match the following: William Jones · Rabindranath Tagore · Thomas Macaulay · Mahatma Gandhi · Pathshalas
→ *Respect for ancient cultures · learning in a natural environment · promotion of English education · critical of English education · gurus.*
2. State whether true or false: (a) James Mill was a severe critic of the Orientalists. (b) Mahatma Gandhi thought promotion of literacy was the most important aim of education. (c) Rabindranath Tagore felt children ought to be subjected to strict discipline. → (a) True. (b) False. (c) False.

3. The English Education Act of 1835 — → *Made English the medium of instruction for higher education and stopped the promotion of Oriental institutions.*
4. Consider the following about Wood's Despatch of 1854:
 1. It argued European learning would create a demand for British goods.
 2. It held that European learning would improve the moral character of Indians.
 3. It recommended reviving the study of Sanskrit and Arabic. → *1 and 2 only. It marked the final triumph of those who **opposed** Oriental learning.*
5. According to William Adam's report of the 1830s, Bengal and Bihar had — → *Over 1 lakh pathshalas teaching over 20 lakh children.*
6. Which of the following best states Gandhi's view? → *Literacy by itself is not education; education should begin with a useful handicraft taught scientifically.*

Mains style

7. "Orientalism combined genuine admiration with a claim to authority." Examine. **(150 words)**
8. "Colonial education policy was shaped more by commercial and administrative needs than by any civilising ideal." Discuss. **(250 words)**
9. "The standardisation of vernacular schools brought order at the cost of access." Comment. **(150 words)**
10. Compare the educational philosophies of Mahatma Gandhi and Rabindranath Tagore. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name three Orientalists, their society and their journal.
- Give the year and purpose of the Calcutta Madrasa and the Hindu College.
- Quote Macaulay's line and give the year of the Act that followed.
- State the two main arguments of Wood's Despatch.
- Give Adam's two numbers and four features of the pathshala.
- What did the post-1854 rules do to poor children, and how was it described?
- State one thing Gandhi and Tagore agreed on and one on which they differed.